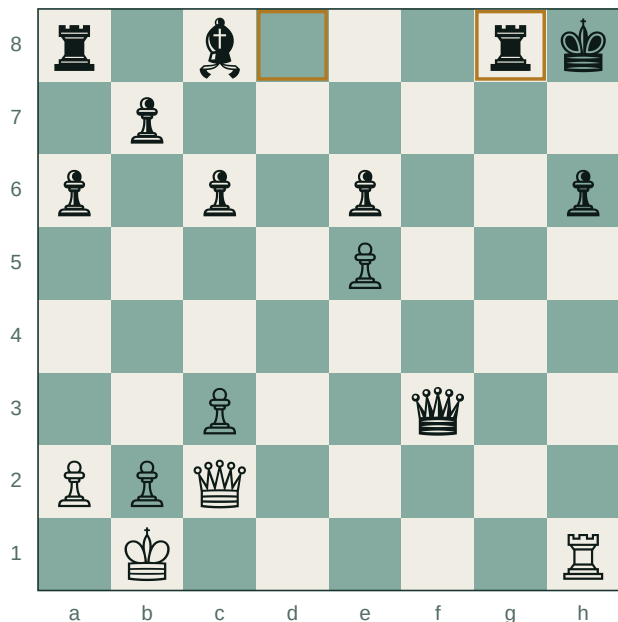


Exposed-king tactics: White, move 26

Exposed-king tactics

White to move



Previous move: 25...Rxd8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26. Rxh6+ Kg7 27. Qh7+ Kf8 28. Rf6+ Qxf6 29. exf6

26.Rxh6+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the pawn on h6. Recorded reply: **26...Kg7**.

27.Qh7+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From h7 it attacks king on g7 and rook on g8. Recorded reply: **27...Kf8**.

28.Rf6+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. From f6 it attacks king on f8 and queen on f3. Recorded reply: **28...Qxf6**.

29.exf6 The pawn captures the queen on f6.

At the end, nominal material is White 13 / Black 17 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +5: the balance goes from -9 to -4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A king without pawns is not automatically mated. Count active attackers and examine escapes toward friendly pieces.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An exposed king gives the attacker checks and access to nearby squares. Coordinate pieces so the checks drive it into a worse net rather than toward safety.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect open files, diagonals, and unprotected squares around the king. Calculate checks in an order that preserves the attack.

The defending king is on h8. Absolute pin: pawn on h6.